domestic demand. India accepted US wheat under the PL-480 program, which allowed India to pay for wheat in local currency. The arrangement was useful because India had limited foreign exchange availability and wheat purchases would have depleted these further. US president Lyndon Johnson decided to slow shipments of wheat to India under PL-480 in what he regarded as an effort to end Indian complacency about improving wheat yields. The US would release wheat shipments only at the last minute in what came to be known as the ‘ship to mouth’ scheme.

Even though Johnson’s intent was to force a positive change in Indian policy, India under Indira saw it as undue pressure. India started importing wheat from Mexico, considering purchase from a fellow developing country as preferable to an overbearing superpower’s aid. India eventually improved its wheat yields, albeit with US assistance in the form of high-yielding variety of seeds and other technical inputs. That goal, however, was achieved only after a mix and match of approaches that included pursuit of autarky through external assistance. More recently, the controversy in India over the use of genetically modified (GM) foods has more to do with the desire not to be dependent on foreign seeds and to produce home-grown food.

Another example of India’s aspiration for self-sufficiency can be found in the constant tension between India and the World Trade Organization (WTO) over trade issues. When India first joined the WTO, it sought an exception under the Trade Related Intellectual Property Rights (TRIPs) rules. Western countries granted ‘product patents’ on new inventions, which precluded the manufacture of a patented product by whatever means without permission of the patent holder. India, since 1970, started granting ‘process patents’, that allowed another inventor or manufacturer to make an already patented product as long as it was created by a novel process. The ‘process patent’ only recognized the uniqueness of the process of manufacturing, not the uniqueness of the end product. ‘In pharmaceuticals,’